

Thinking independently

During adolescence, rapid brain development means that teens begin to use new ways of thinking. One really important ability is independent thought, which helps to boost a teen's self-esteem and prepares them for the future.

What is independent thought?

When a person is able to think on their own and make informed decisions, without anyone guiding their thoughts or decision-making, they are demonstrating independent thought. People begin to think independently as young children, but it takes time and practice to cultivate the skill. During the teen years, a person's ability to think independently advances quickly, because the parts of the brain responsible for cognition begin to develop rapidly. While their brain function is expanding, teens are continually refining the skills that help them to become independent individuals, learning from examples set by others, and by their own trial and error.

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“The essence of the independent mind lies not in what it thinks, but in how it thinks.”

Christopher Hitchens—
journalist, author, critic

Thinking skills in adolescence

Brain growth in adolescence allows teens to develop complex thinking processes—such as abstract thinking, reason, comparison, and empathy—encouraging independent thought and behavior.

Abstract thinking

This way of thinking considers possibilities and ideas that are not physically present.



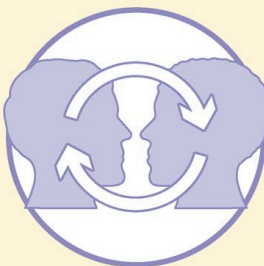
Reasoning

This thought process involves a person looking at all the facts of a situation logically and analytically to form their own opinions and ideas, plus questions for further research and understanding.



Comparing different viewpoints

This trait leads to a greater understanding of topics, and provokes questions for debate.



Empathy

This attribute enables a person to see things from another's perspective, and to understand their point of view. It is an important part of healthy and successful relationships.

